



Welcome, and a Note About How I Teach

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I am writing this so you know the kind of classroom you have walked into, and the kind of teacher you have in me. From day one I want you to understand what I care about, how I think about learning, and how we are going to work together this summer.

Here is the first thing to know about me: I am a language nut. I have spent fifteen years on Portuguese, most of it picked up in Brazilian restaurants around Massachusetts, with Rosetta Stone helping on the side. I have put in another fifteen years on Spanish, ten on French, eight on Japanese, and five on Mandarin. That last one included a year living and teaching in Qingdao, which mostly taught me how much I did not know. I tell you this not to flex but to confess that I am the learner sitting right next to you. I know what it feels like to want to say something and have your brain stall halfway across the bridge. I also know the small win of finally getting a sentence out, and the bigger one of getting it wrong and laughing about it.

I should also tell you where I come from, because it shapes how I teach. I am a Berklee graduate myself, and I came here for music education and never really stopped being a student. I started out as a drummer, an orchestral percussionist who lived inside rhythm, and for a long time that was my entire musical world. Then I sat down at a piano, and everything opened up: I could finally see how harmony and melody fit together, and learning itself became the part of music I loved most. That is the feeling I am chasing for you with English, the moment a door swings open and you realize how much more there is on the other side. I also spent more than ten years teaching music to kids in Boston public schools, which is where I learned that a lesson has to be fun or it simply does not stick. We are adults here, but I have not forgotten that rule, so expect to play, to laugh, and to enjoy the work as we do it.

Here is the second thing, and it is the one that matters most. I am not interested in getting you across a finish line. I am interested in getting you to love the marathon.

What does that look like in our class? In a lot of specific ways, and across a lot of different kinds of days. We will listen to songs and pull them apart line by line, working out what the lyrics actually mean and why someone wrote them that way. We will write real paragraphs and record short spoken messages, so you get used to hearing your own English out loud. We will walk parts of Boston and name what we see, because a word sticks far better when it is attached to a place you have actually stood in. We will treat grammar as patterns to feel rather than rules to memorize, and we will talk, a lot, about where we come from and where we want to go. Some days we will make something real, a podcast episode, a poem, a small presentation, and other days we will simply slow down and read closely together.

It means I will not be the teacher who hands you the answer. Instead I will build up to it with you, ask questions, sometimes too many of them, and call on you even when you did not raise your hand, because there is no coasting here and far too much to gain. I will learn your name before I learn what you already know about English, since the first of those matters more. I will give extensions when you

need them, and I will tell you, gently and specifically, where you can push harder. And I would rather you produce a real thing, a podcast episode, a poem, a paragraph you actually meant, than ace a worksheet you forget by Friday.

It means I will treat the so-called rules of English less like a rulebook to obey and more like a groove you are learning to feel. There are patterns; you will internalize them. But English is a hand-me-down from a thousand other languages and it contradicts itself constantly. Your job is not to memorize every exception. Your job is to develop an ear, an eye, an instinct, the same way a drummer learns the pocket: by playing in it badly until one day, without noticing, you are in it.

It means I will use whatever helps you specifically. Cross-linguistic comparisons (the speakers of Spanish, Portuguese, French, Japanese, and Mandarin in the room will hear me reach across). Music. Memes. Wikipedia wormholes. Custom examples written for you, on the spot, using the word you are stuck on and the topic you actually care about. I have spent the last two years building tools to make that kind of hyper-custom teaching possible, and I will use them with you, openly. They are not a shortcut around the work; they are an amplifier for it.

And it means I will admit, often, that I do not know. I started rowing a few months ago on the Charles River. My coach yells a command in rowing jargon and I want to yell back, "I am doing that!", right before I realize that I am not. I am terrible at it, and I love it. That is the posture I want you to bring to English: the willingness to be a beginner in public, the patience to let your neurons catch up, and the curiosity to ask one more question when your brain is already tired.

Now, the marathon part.

Most of you will not "finish" learning English in this class. Neither will I, in any of the five languages I keep tending. The truth no one tells you in language school is that fluency is not a destination, it is a relationship. You will be in this relationship the rest of your life, and you get to decide what kind it is. I want you to decide it is one you enjoy. I want you to find the part of English that is yours: the song lyrics that finally click, the slang you can wield, the email you sent without rereading three times, the conversation with a stranger that went on longer than you thought it could. Those are the miles that compound. Those are why people keep running.

So here is the deal. Show up. Try things. Drop the ball and pick it up (my dad taught me to juggle in third grade, and the drop is the point, not the failure). Ask. Tinker. Be a little annoyed at me when I do not hand you the answer. Be a little proud of yourself when you find it.

I am glad you are here.

Kramer